

PRICING & EDITIONING

Part 1: Pricing



Why We Price Our Art

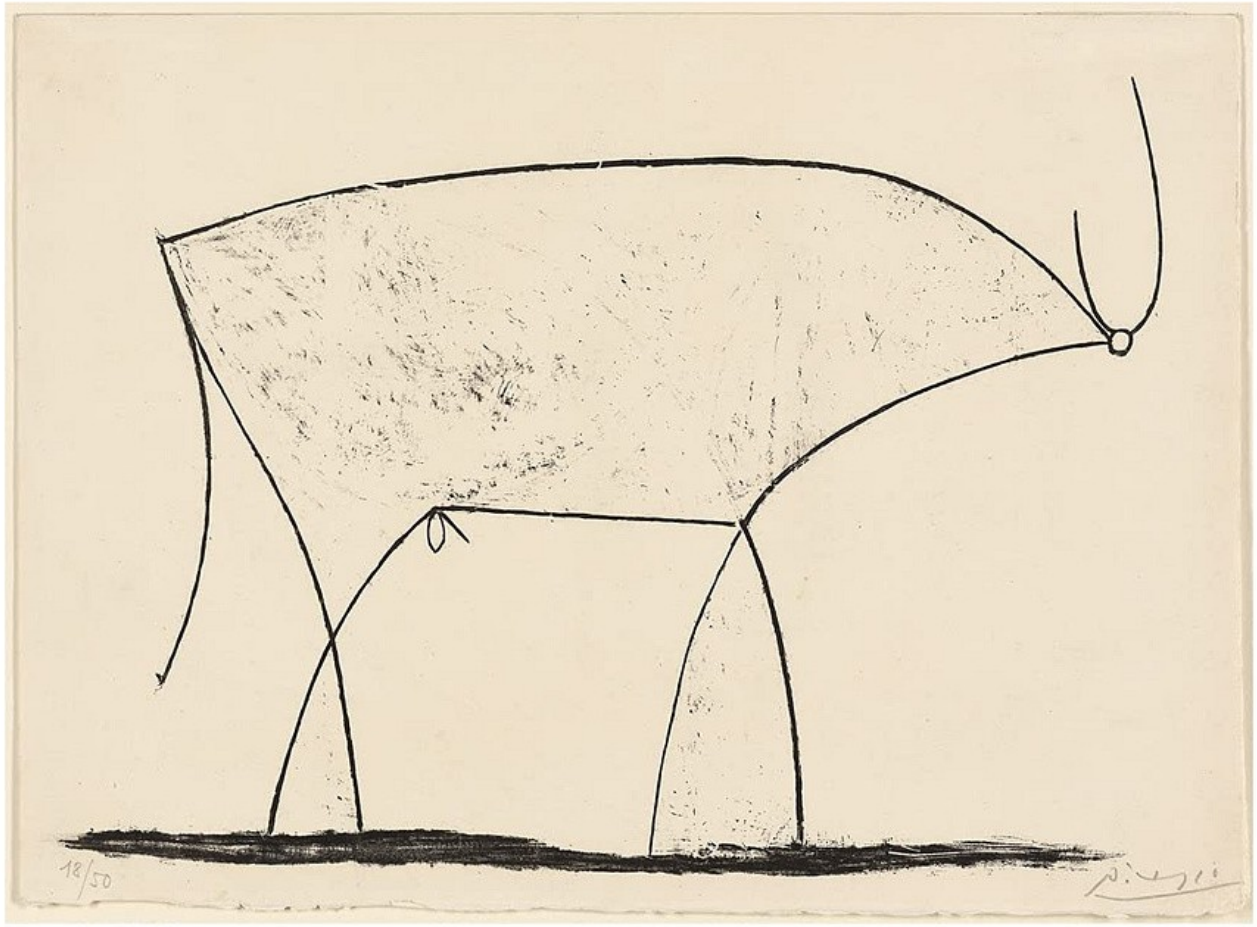
- Pricing well means getting support for your practice and the ability/freedom to make more work.
- Artists should value their labor, ideas, experience, and time — not just their materials.

Artistic Worth

- Failing to sell a piece for a given price doesn't mean that the work lacks value.
- Succeeding at selling a piece doesn't necessarily confirm that work is better than another.
- Mediocre work can command high prices because of many factors: reputation, scarcity, speculative markets, or the backing of a few key individuals.
- You may create a particularly meaningful work that can't be priced at what it should be worth.
- The good work you make may have little or no established market.



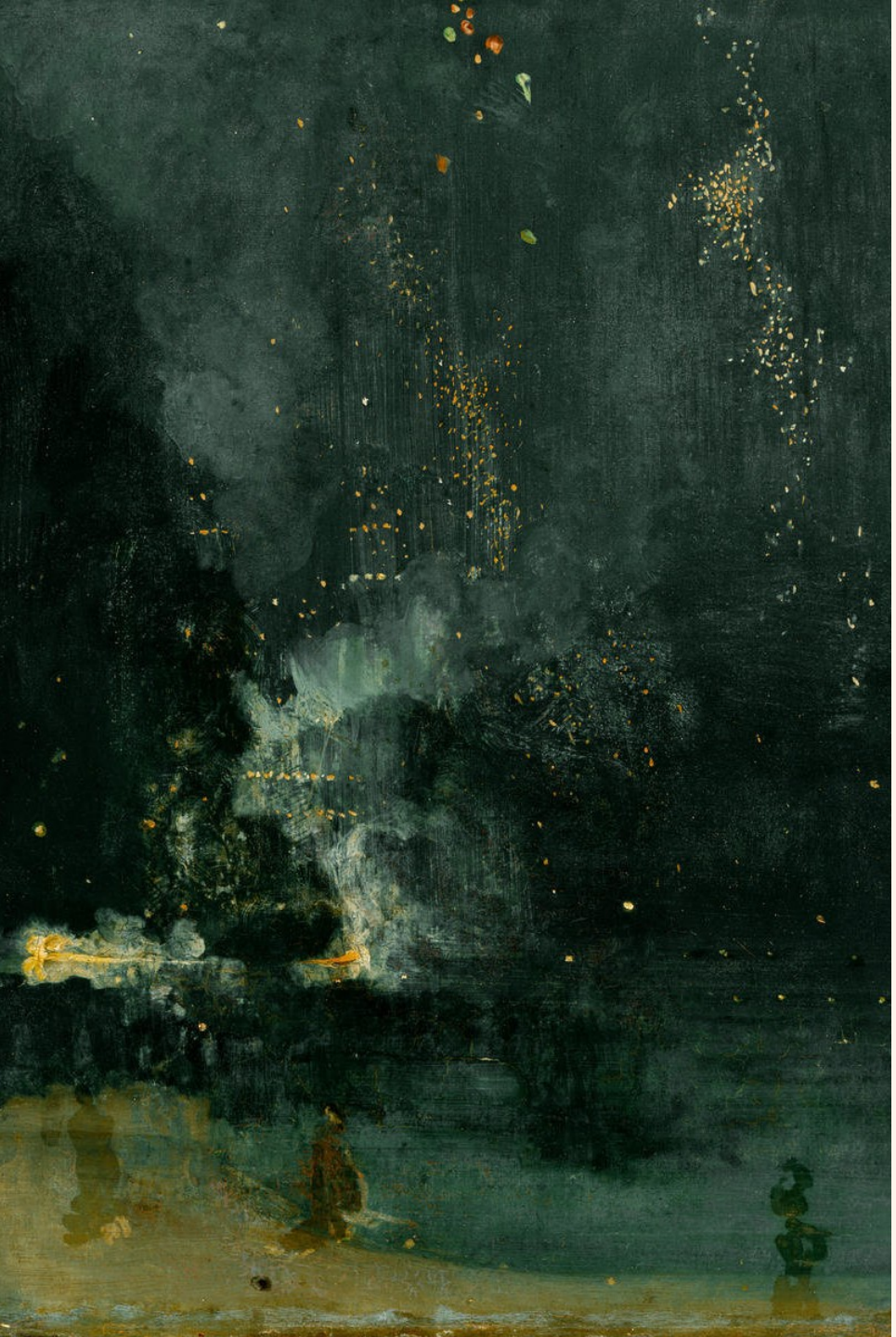
You should value your time, ideas, labor — as well as your skill and all the work you put into developing that skill.



Picasso:

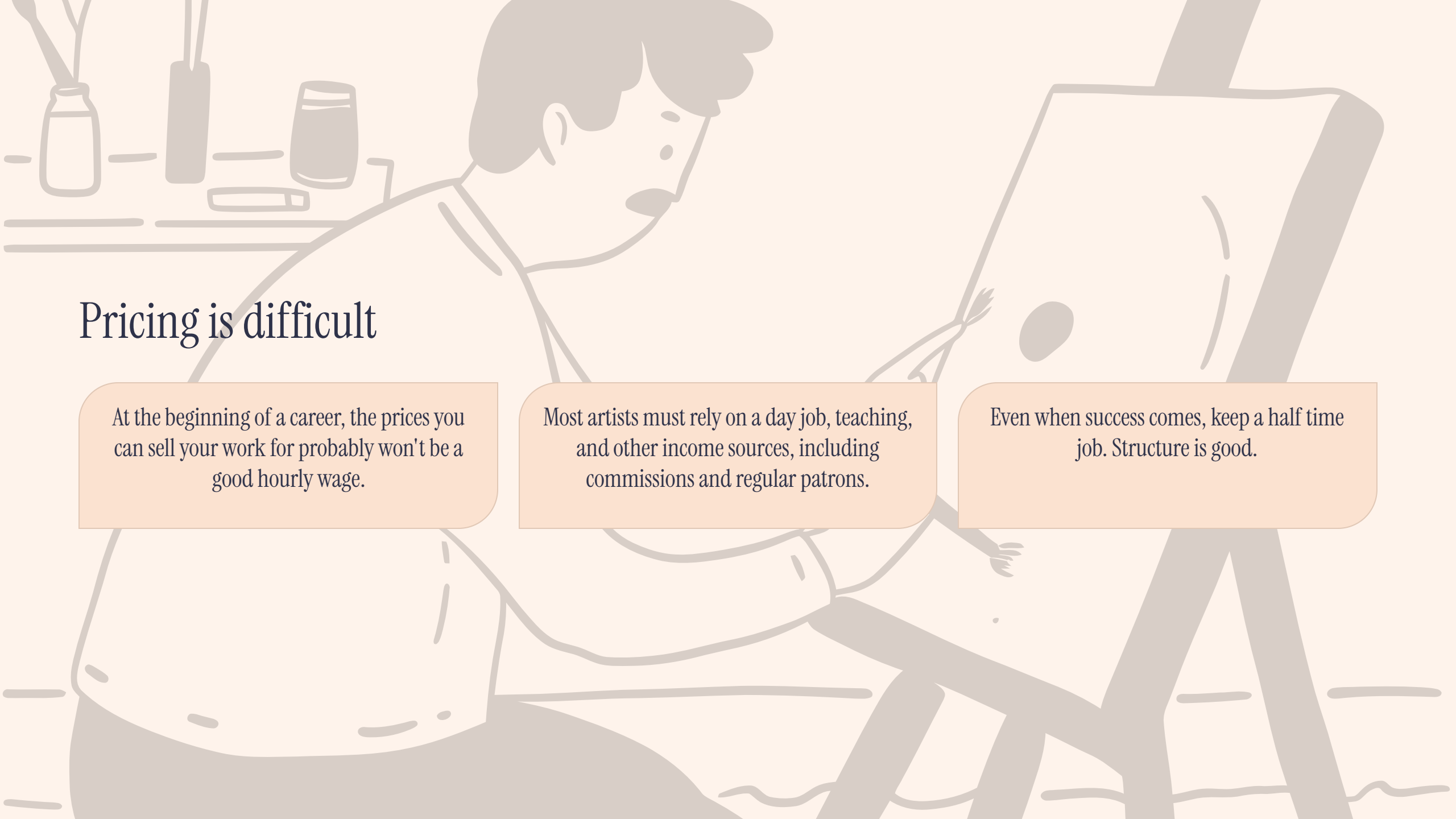
"But you did that in thirty seconds"

"No, it has taken me forty years to do that."



James Whistler:

"He did not ask 200 guineas for two days' work; he asked it for the knowledge he had gained in the work of a lifetime."



Pricing is difficult

At the beginning of a career, the prices you can sell your work for probably won't be a good hourly wage.

Most artists must rely on a day job, teaching, and other income sources, including commissions and regular patrons.

Even when success comes, keep a half time job. Structure is good.

If you want to create meaningful work, you must remove the need for every artwork you create to help support you financially.

Removing that pressure protects your joy and the experimentation necessary to make good art.



What we're not doing:

Pricing based on emotions (e.g. this is one my favorite pieces, so it should cost more)

Pricing that's all over the place, so two similar looking pieces have wildly different prices (confuses collectors)

Overpricing larger pieces just because they're big or underpricing smaller pieces just based on their dimensions.

Don't trust the calculators

Basic formula:

Width × Height = Square Inches

Square Inches × Price per Square Inch = Base Price

Example: 24 × 36 in. = 864 sq. in.
864 × $4.50 = $3,888 (round up to $3,900)

This idea gets tossed around because it helps:

- Keeps similarly sized works priced consistently
- But it doesn't inherently take into account what it cost to make the work.
- It also doesn't answer the question of whether or not the market can support that price

When determining an artwork's price you have to balance two categories:

What It Costs to Make the Work

1. Production Costs (materials, fabrication, framing, etc.)
2. Your labor as an artist
3. The overhead to maintain your studio

Where It Sits in the Market

1. The artists exhibition and sales history
2. What comparable works go for in your market (at that scale and in that medium)
3. The strength of current demand, and the purchasing capacity of current collectors
4. What collectors in your region are willing to pay for an artist at your career stage

The price you set is a combination of all these factors.

Find Your Peers & Identify Comparables

It takes humility to learn to price your work well. Recognizing your place in the market can be humbling.

You want to research the prices of comparable artists. This includes artists with:

- Similar career stage
- Similar medium, scale, or mode of production
- Similar geographic market
- Similar exhibition or institutional history
- Similar gallery representation
- Similar collector base and sales channels

Prices Develop Within Geographic Markets

Your art market is often regional before it becomes national or international.

Your local market significantly influences what collectors are accustomed to paying and thus what you can price your work at while you're growing your art practice.

Local Market Factors

Collector wealth, cost of living, and gallery infrastructure.

Buying Habits

Whether collectors regularly purchase from emerging artists.

Comparable Artists

Pricing of similar artists in the same geographic region.

Audience Reach

Consider if your audience is local, national, or international.

While geography helps determine your overall price range, the same work should maintain the same retail price wherever it is offered, regardless of its location.

Calculating Studio Overhead

Rather than trying to calculate exact costs per work, determine a reasonable annual allocation.

`Annual studio overhead ÷ number of works produced annually = overhead allocation per work`

For example: `$12,000 annual studio expenses ÷ 40 works = $300 overhead per work`

This typically includes:

- Studio rent, utilities, insurance
- Equipment and software
- Storage and general studio supplies
- Website and administrative expenses

Create a consistent price structure for unique works

Example #1

12" × 16" – $480

24" × 36" – $1,200

36" × 48" – $2,000

Example #2

12" × 16" – $1,500Offer Alternatives –

24" × 36" – $3,500

36" × 48" – $5,500

Even as you price consistently within a given medium and at a given size: you may still need to adjust for expensive fabrication or materials—but you must keep the price credible within the overall market.

When One Medium Undermines Another

Some Examples:

If a unique drawing is priced at $1,200 but a similarly sized editioned print is priced $1,500, the collector may wonder why the unique work is worth less.

If a small sculpture costs $900, while a similarly sized painting is 3x that, one of those works may look artificially inflated or deflated. It raises questions.

If you release a $100 open edition print that looks almost identical in size and presentation to a $1,000 limited edition, you may weaken the perceived distinction between the two.

If works on paper are always dramatically cheaper than paintings simply because they are on paper, you may unintentionally teach collectors that those works are less important even when they are equally central to your practice.

The art world loves to create hierarchies.

Paintings > Drawings > Limited-Edition Prints > Open Editions

For example, an artist might have:

1. 24" × 30" painting
   $3,500
2. 18" × 24" unique drawing
   $1,500
3. 18" × 24" limited-edition print, edition of 20
   $500–$750
4. 18" × 24" open-edition or time-limited print
   $100–$300

Those are just examples and not recommended universal amounts or percentages.



Pricing Once You Have a Gallery

Most galleries are doing a 50:50 split, or a 40:60 split in some cases, to help cover:

- Rent
- Staff
- Marketing
- Shipping costs
- Art fair booth costs

In exchange, you're essentially hiring an expert salesman with connections. So getting gallery representation gets you support and opens doors, in the best of cases, to people you never would have access to otherwise. But it changes the economics of how you need to think about pricing.

Target Net

Target Net is how much you need to receive as an artist from each sale.

We already talked about calculating:

1. Production Costs (materials, fabrication, framing, etc.)
2. Your labor as an artist
3. The overhead to maintain your studio

Now you need to factor in:

4. Gallery commission
5. Discounts to collectors

You need to work backwards through the numbers to come up with what the minimum is that you need to make from a piece.

Target Net Formula

Retail price = (desired artist earnings + production costs + allocated studio overhead) ÷ artist's retained percentage

Example: 50% Gallery Commission

Desired artist earnings: $2,000

Production costs: $400

Allocated studio overhead: $300

The Math

$2,000 + $400 + $300 = $2,700 needed by artist

$2,700 ÷ 0.50 = $5,400 retail

What to do when the number is too high

The Target Net formula tells you what a work needs to cost to achieve a sustainable financial target.

What it doesn't tell you is whether or not the market can support that price.

Possible Solutions



The double-edged sword of pricing

Overpricing can:

- Place you in competition with substantially more established peers
- Prevent early collectors from entering your market
- Produce an appearance of demand that doesn't exist
- Cause work to remain unsold for years
- Make needed reductions in price awkward or even reputationally damaging

Underpricing can:

- Signal immaturity and uncertainty around your practice
- Make creating work financially unsustainable longterm
- Place obstacles to later gallery representation
- Create resentment and burnout

When to Raise Prices

1. A body of work is selling repeatedly
2. When you make multiple news works available they sell soon after
3. You get regular inquiries and a sustained waiting list for new work develops
4. Supply is consistently failing to meet demand
5. A new body of work involves substantially greater scale or production
6. Your exhibition history or institutional recognition passes big milestones
7. You get gallery representation

Don't make abrupt changes. Increase prices gradually, with a clear game plan.

Review Your Current Prices Every 6–12 Months

Check against some key metrics:

- Percentage of available work sold
- Time from release to sale
- Which sizes and mediums move most
- Length of your waiting-list
- Number of inquiries versus purchases
- If you have repeat collectors
- If discounts are needed to close sales
- Regional differences in demand
- Whether your production can remain sustainable

A note about discounts

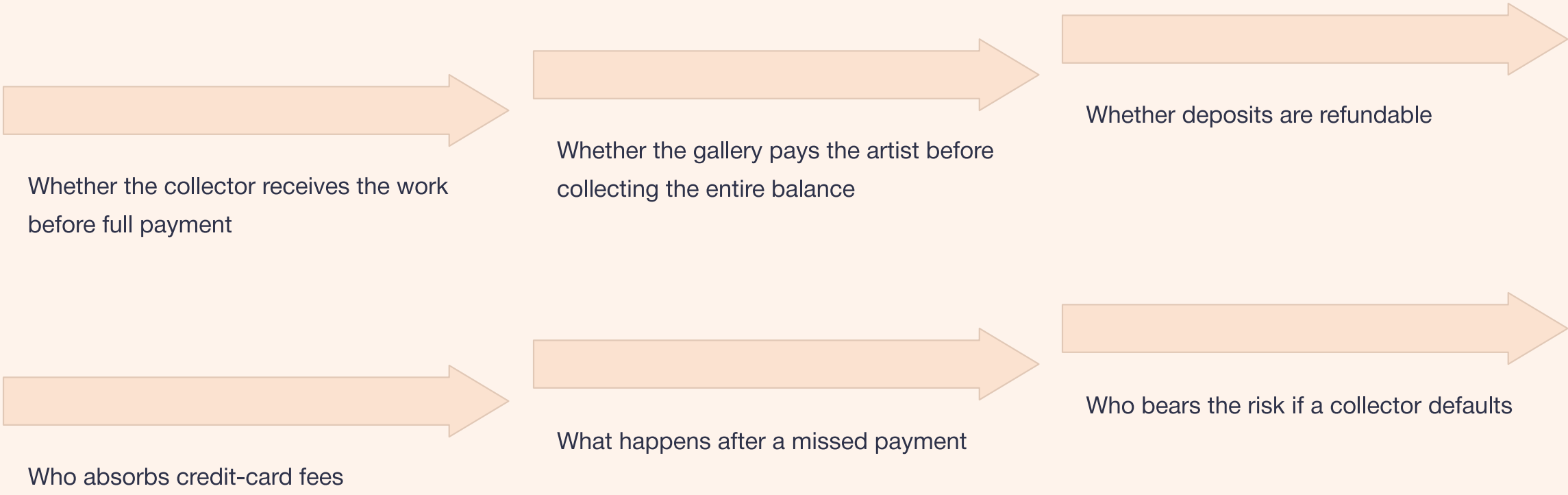
There's a big difference between publicly reducing the list price versus privately offering a courtesy discount to an individual collector or group.

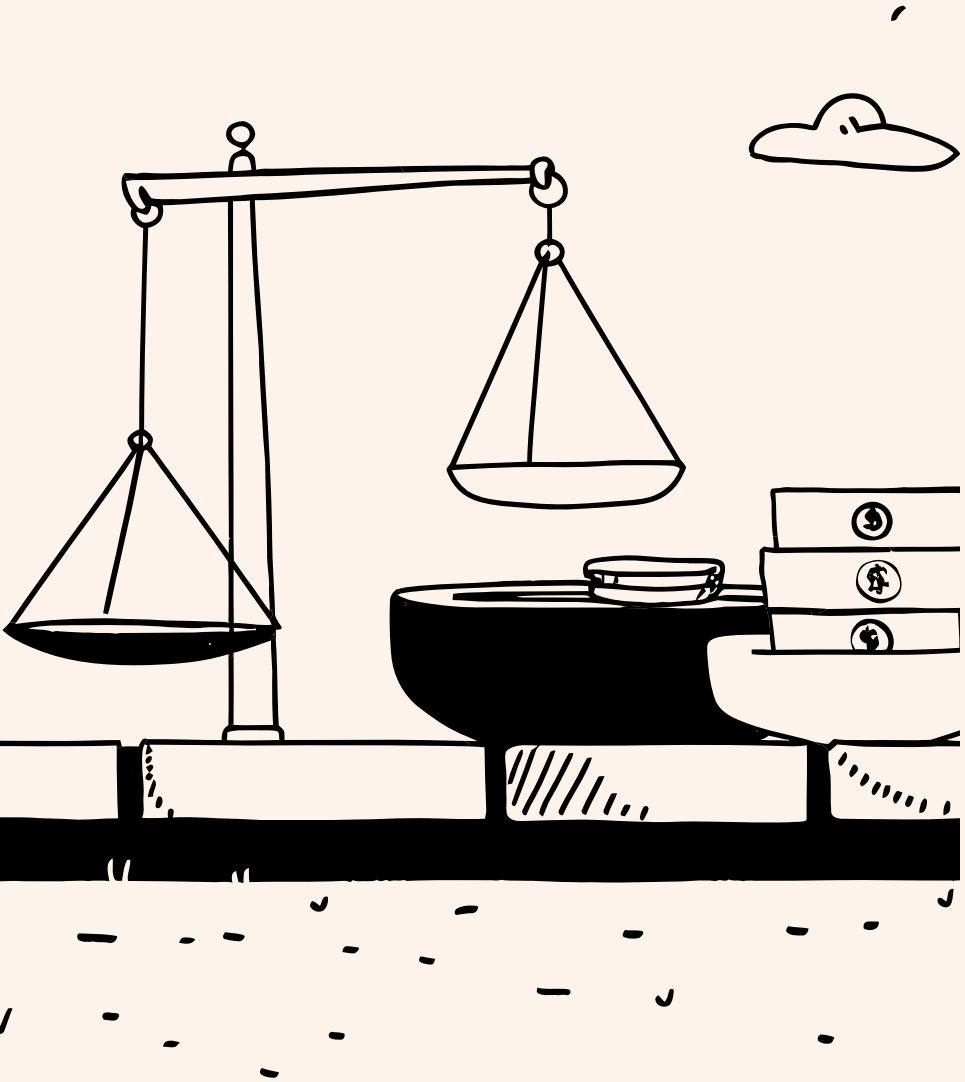
Types of Discounts:

- A private courtesy discount
- A volume discount
- A museum or institutional discount
- A payment plan

Payment plans and credit risk

Artists and their gallery should decide:





Maintain one price for a work across all galleries, fairs, and from your studio

Prices should remain the same in all places a collector might look.

Managing Your Inventory

A good pricing strategy includes figuring out how to manage your inventory.

This can include:



Reserving strong works for upcoming exhibitions



Combining pieces into coherent bodies of work



Holding back some pieces from each body of work for museum acquisition



Maintaining an artist archive with reference examples



There's a big difference though, between managing availability, and manufacturing a false sense of scarcity.

You should always control how much of your work enters the market at one time.

Releasing work in smaller, more coherent groups, can help collectors understand your work by creating a sense of focus. It also helps prevent your own inventory from competing against itself.

Don't Create Artificial Scarcity

This includes:

1. Claiming a work is "almost sold out" when it isn't
2. Falsely implying that collectors are competing for the same work
3. Pretending something isn't available when you have multiples sitting in storage

Don’t change the edition size halfway through, which might include:

- Creating an edition of 100, selling 10, and then deciding to call it sold out
- Holding work back to give the impression everything sold
- Expanding or contracting an edition after collectors have purchased a numbered edition

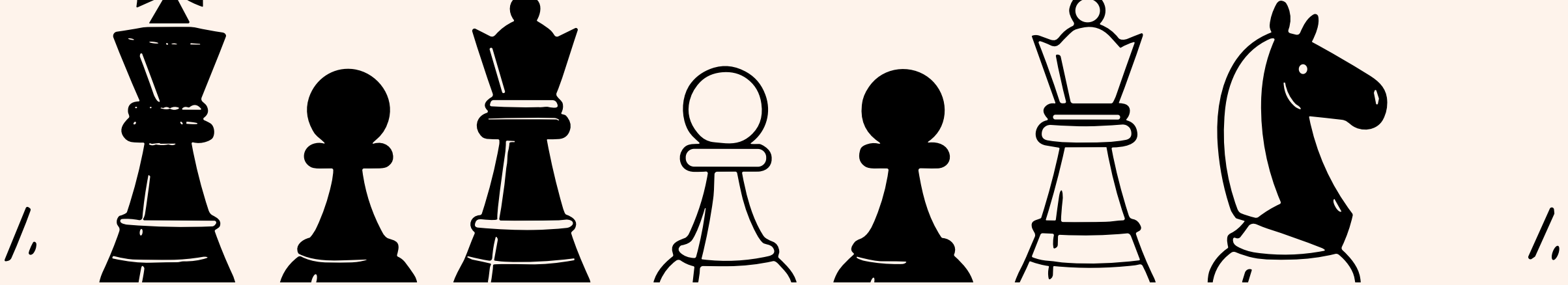
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You want to avoid artificial scarcity while still managing supply responsibly.

The distinction is this:

Responsible scarcity	Artificial scarcity
is deliberately pacing when and how work becomes available.	is trying to make a collector believe there's more demand or less supply than actually exists.

“The supply of your work should grow alongside the demand for it.”



Auctions and the Secondary Market

Be especially careful about participating in auctions.

These are not merely sales venues. Auction results become public comparison points that can have long-lasting effects on your pricing strategy.

Low Results

A low result can negatively influence future price negotiations for your primary market sales.

High Results

Very high results can prematurely pressure primary-market price increases, often out of sync with demand.

Unsold Work Affects Perception

Even an unsold or "bought-in" work may affect future sales prospects and perceptions around your work.

Artists and galleries must discuss any prior auction appearances before new work is consigned to ensure alignment.

Auction Language

Auction prices are easy to misunderstand because several different numbers can get reported as “the price.” Understanding these key terms is crucial for accurate valuation.

Estimate

The auction house’s expected range for the work.

Reserve

The confidential minimum price the seller is willing to accept. If bidding doesn’t reach it, the work may go unsold.

Hammer Price

The winning bid when the auctioneer brings down the hammer.

Buyer’s Premium

An additional fee the buyer pays to the auction house on top of the hammer price.

Bought In

The work failed to sell, often because bidding did not reach the reserve.

Seller’s Net

What the seller actually receives after the auction house takes its commissions and other agreed expenses.

Charity Auctions and Gifts

These kinds of opportunities are not standard sales channels, but they must fit within into your overall pricing strategy.

The key risk is that a work sold at a heavily discounted price, even for a good cause, can be seen as its market value if those results become public.



Set a Sensible Reserve Price

Ensure any work sold through auction has a minimum sale price that protects its market value.



Consider Result Transparency

Be aware if the charity auction publishes results, as low public sales can negatively influence future pricing discussions.



Protect Your Main Editions

Be strategic about what you donate. Avoid giving away a standard edition of your primary work if it risks devaluing the rest of that edition.



Offer Alternatives

Instead, consider donating a special proof, an experience, or a unique fundraising work instead.

When the work doesn't sell

1

A show doesn't have to sell out to be successful.

2

Sales are only one measure of an exhibition's value.

3

A show can create reviews, curator relationships, institutional interest, future commissions, and longer-term collector support.

4

Selling 50% of a show in a difficult market can be a tremendous success.

